

Hormuz disruption boosts Duqm as supply chain hub

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Hormuz disruption positions Duqm to attract rerouted supply chain investment

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Duqm is best placed to attract supply chain redundancy investment driven by Hormuz disruption risk, as the Omani port city combines direct Arabian Sea access with an integrated industrial platform, significant expansion capacity, and logistics infrastructure.

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Yanbu, on Saudi Arabia's Red Sea coast, offers proven energy export potential but faces physical capacity constraints that limit its role as a diversified logistics and manufacturing platform.

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Bypass corridors through Iraq and Syria face high execution risk and weak commercial fundamentals relative to established port infrastructure on the Arabian Peninsula.

Duqm is best positioned to attract supply chain redundancy investment. Markets have largely focused on whether Hormuz could close again, but the more important commercial question is where capital flows if disruptions become a recurring feature of Gulf trade. Duqm stands out for its expansion headroom, investment breadth across logistics, industrial, and energy infrastructure, and early signs that capital is already moving into this ecosystem. Rather than replacing Hormuz, governments and companies are likely to build redundancy around it through alternative ports, pipelines, storage, multimodal transport, warehousing, and industrial zones.

Direct ocean access is necessary—but not sufficient—to attract investment. Direct Arabian Sea access is necessary, but valuable only when paired with infrastructure that allows companies to move, process, store, and distribute cargo efficiently. Ports that combine maritime access with industrial zones, pipelines, storage, multimodal transport, warehousing, and expansion capacity reduce the incremental investment needed to redesign supply chains and therefore attract a broader range of commercial activity.

As Gulf economies diversify, these logistics platforms increasingly support refining, petrochemicals, bulk commodity imports, manufacturing inputs, consumer goods distribution, free-zone manufacturing, and regional warehousing—not simply crude exports. Their importance, therefore, extends beyond energy security to the wider diversification strategies of Gulf economies.

Duqm offers the broadest commercial resilience platform. Duqm combines deep-water Arabian Sea access with the Special Economic Zone Authority of Duqm (SEZAD), refinery capacity, storage, dry dock facilities, warehousing, manufacturing zones, and the ongoing Basin 2 port expansion. Rather than serving a single commodity or export function, it provides an integrated platform capable of supporting energy, manufacturing, logistics, and regional distribution simultaneously, making it well positioned to attract the broadest range of resilience-driven investment.

Ras Markaz functions primarily as a large storage and export hub linked to Duqm Refinery. Its value comes from expanding storage and export flexibility outside Hormuz. While it is unlikely to emerge as a diversified logistics platform, it strengthens the resilience of the wider Duqm complex.

Yanbu supports energy resilience rather than broader diversification. Yanbu benefits from the East-West Pipeline, a large refining complex, and state-developed industrial city infrastructure. Its comparative advantage lies in bolstering Saudi Arabia's export resilience rather than serving as a diversified logistics platform.

Yanbu's effective crude loading capacity runs at roughly 4 million barrels per day (bpd) under sustained wartime conditions, against a pipeline feed of 7 million bpd, of which approximately 5 million bpd is available for export. The remainder supplies local refineries. Observed peak crude loadings plateaued near 4 million–4.3 million bpd even as the pipeline ran at capacity, with berthing friction, Very Large Crude Carrier scheduling windows, and tidal constraints limiting throughput below the theoretical ceiling. Closing that gap would require additional berths and tank farm investment that Saudi Aramco has not yet publicly committed to. These physical constraints limit Yanbu's role as a full Hormuz substitute.

Fujairah remains exposed to regional security risks. Fujairah sits on the Gulf of Oman outside the Strait of Hormuz, so it avoids the chokepoint itself, and it has already proven its value as a resilience asset. It is also attracting investment to expand existing capacity. But it remains within range of Iranian missiles, drones, and other military capabilities. Its pipeline and export infrastructure are approaching higher utilization; still, Duqm's larger expansion capacity and integrated platform provide greater long-term potential for incremental resilience-driven logistics and manufacturing investment.

Commercial adoption will separate viable resilience projects from political ambition. Several proposed bypass projects—including Iraq's pipeline routes to Turkey (Ceyhan), Syria (Baniyas), and Jordan (Aqaba)—face execution risks including cross-border coordination, financing requirements, and persistent security concerns, particularly for routes through Iraq and Syria where regional infrastructure remains exposed to conflict. Even where projects move forward, longer transport distances, higher operating costs, and uncertain commercial demand may limit their competitiveness against existing export infrastructure.

Private capital is therefore more likely to fund incremental expansion of proven logistics platforms than entirely new corridors whose commercial case remains uncertain (see table below).

Sector impacts will be concentrated on logistics and trade-enabling infrastructure, with ports, industrial zones, energy export infrastructure, and supply chain services the primary beneficiaries of resilience-driven investment (please see table below).

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